Who are the first responders?

No matter how large or small, local communities are expected to provide immediate disaster response. On a daily basis, **police officers, firefighters, and emergency medical technicians** are a community's first responders, whether during fire, flood or acts of terrorism. Mental health professionals and the community's hospitals may also be activated in those early minutes and hours after disaster.

Disaster management includes Prevention, Mitigation, Preparedness, Response and Recovery. Disaster management involves all levels of government. Non-governmental and community based organizations play a vital role in the process. Modern disaster management goes beyond post-disaster assistance. It now includes pre-disaster planning and preparedness activities, organizational planning, training, information management, public relations and many other fields. Crisis management is important, but is only a part of the responsibility of a disaster manager.



Disaster Management Cycle

The traditional approach to disaster management has a number of phased sequences of action or a continuum. These can be represented as a disaster management cycle. We mainly focus on the way how the community should respond to disasters.

8.1.1 Earthquake

An earthquake is a sudden vibration of the part of the earth caused by plate movements. It occurs along the plate boundaries. The place inside the earth where an earthquake originates is **focus**. The point on the earth's surface above the called a focus is called an **epicentre**. The damage caused by the earthquake is the highest near the **epicentre**. The earthquake is measured by an instrument called a **Seismograph**. It is recorded in **Richter scale**. Let us now see how the communities can better respond to earthquakes.

DO YOU KNOW?

1. Japan is in a very active seismic area and it has the densest seismic network in the world.

2. Which country actually has the most number of earthquakes? Indonesia is in a very active seismic zone also, but because it is larger than Japan, it has more earthquakes.

3. Which countries have the most earthquakes per unit area? This would probably be Tonga, Fiji or Indonesia, since they are all in extremely active seismic areas along subduction zones.

What to do during an earthquake?

Be aware that some earthquakes are actually foreshocks and a larger earthquake might occur later. Minimize your movements to a few steps that reach a safe place nearby and stay indoors until the shaking has stopped and you are sure exiting is safe.

If indoors

1. DROP to the ground; take COVER by getting under a sturdy table or other piece of furniture and HOLD ON until the shaking stops. If there is no table or desk near you, cover your face and head with your arms and crouch in an inside corner of the building.
2. Protect yourself by staying under the lintel of an inner door, in the corner of a room, under a table or even under a bed.
3. Stay away from glass windows, outside doors and walls and anything that could fall (such as lighting fixtures or furniture).
4. Stay inside until the shaking stops and go outside.

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